which determines “the state of the world with regard to that particular subsystem.”

A small system *S* does not distinguish the details of the rest of the universe because it interacts only with a few among the variables of the rest of the universe. The entropy of the universe *with respect to S* counts the (micro)states of the universe undistinguishable *by S*. The universe appears in a high-entropy configuration *with respect to S*, because (by definition) there are more microstates in high-entropy configurations, therefore it is more likely to happen to be in one of these microstates.

As explained above, there is a *flow* associated with high-entropy configurations, and the parameter of this flow is *thermal time*. For a generic small system *S*, entropy remains generally high along the entire flow of thermal time, perhaps just fluctuating up and down, because, after all, we are dealing here with probabilities, not fixed rules.

But among the innumerable small systems *S* that exist in this extraordinarily vast universe where we happen to live, there will be a few special ones for which the fluctuations of the entropy happen to be such that *at one of the two ends* of the flow of thermal time entropy happens to be low. For *these* systems *S*, the fluctuation is not symmetrical: entropy increases. This growth is what we experience as the flowing of time. What is special is not the state of the early universe: it is the small system *S* to which we belong.

I’m not sure if we are dealing with a plausible story, but I do not know of any better ones. The alternative is to accept as a given of observation the fact that entropy was low at the beginning of the universe, and to leave it at that.[96]

It is the law announced by Clausius, $\Delta S \geq 0$, and deciphered by Boltzmann that is guiding us: entropy never decreases. Having lost sight of it, in search of the general laws of the world, we rediscover it as a possible perspective effect for particular subsystems. Let’s begin again from there.